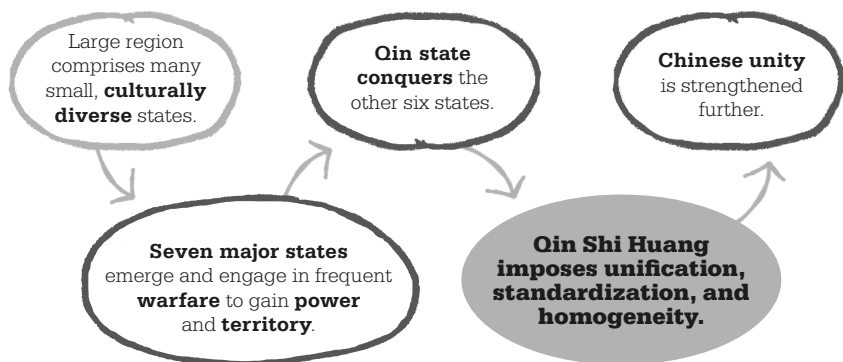




power and his successor, Zi Ying, found his authority so reduced that he adopted the title of king, rather than emperor.

The Han Dynasty

China collapsed into rebellion and civil unrest, and a few days after Zi Ying's accession, the Han general Liu Bang marched into Xianyang. The following year, in 206 BCE, he declared himself emperor of the Han dynasty, which would go on to rule China for 400 years, shaping its subsequent history to such an extent that the main ethnic group in China is now known as the Han.

The Han expanded Chinese territory in all directions—west to Xinjiang and Central Asia, northeast to Manchuria and Korea, and south to Yunnan, Hainan, and Vietnam. Most importantly, they consumed the powerful Xiongnu Empire in the north. They also reintroduced Confucianism as the official state philosophy: Confucian education and ethics soon became the cornerstones of the scholar-bureaucracy, eventually forming the basis for the all-important civil service examination system, which would give a meritocratic basis to imperial institutions and combat the power of the aristocracy for millennia to come.

Han success in building and maintaining a unified, centralized China was based on the foundations that had been laid down by the First Emperor. The Han dynasty finally collapsed in 220 CE, amid a foment of civil unrest and natural disasters that convinced the Chinese that

their dynasty had lost “the mandate of heaven,” giving way to the violent and chaotic era known as the Three Kingdoms and Six Dynasties Period. Despite the devastating cost of this breakdown, which saw the Chinese population plummet from 54 million in 156 CE to 16 million in 280 CE, the concept of a unified China survived 360 years of division, enabling the Sui dynasty to reunify China in 581.

The influence of the First Emperor is still felt in modern China, and Chairman Mao Zedong (1893–1976) explicitly drew on the emperor for inspiration. “You accuse us of acting like Qin Shi Huang,” Mao thundered in a 1958 tirade against intellectual critics. “You are wrong. We surpass him a hundred times. When you berate us for imitating his despotism, we are happy to agree! Your mistake was that you did not say so enough.” ■



Confucius is generally considered to be the most influential philosopher in Chinese history. His teachings emphasized the importance of morality, integrity, humility, and self-discipline.